

When we think about the origins of “modern” or “contemporary” film theory we often have the academicization of film theory in mind. We might think of the late 1960s and 1970s, and of works that established lines of thought about the cinematic apparatus, representation of politicized identities, and audience experience that continue to extend today, such as Peter Wollen’s *Signs and Meaning in the Cinema* (1969); Donald Bogle’s *Toms, Coons, Mulattoes, Mammies, and Bucks: An Interpretive History of Blacks in American Films* (1973); Amos Vogel’s *Film as a Subversive Art* (1974); Molly Haskell’s *From Reverence to Rape: The Treatment of Women in Movies* (1974); Laura Mulvey’s “Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema” (1975); or Christian Metz’s *The Imaginary Signifier* (translated into English in 1977). Yet only two of these authors—Bogle and Metz—were academics at the time. Wollen and Mulvey would go on to become university faculty, but my point is that this foundational scholarship was written not for a field but for a culture. That is, what we might in retrospect think of as *academic* film theory was really an aspect of a cultural practice, a mechanism within the larger post-1960s grand project of theory, one that sought to ameliorate ideological injustices by better understanding the signs and images that comprise so much of culture, and by looking especially to mainstream cinema as a dominant source of this ideological dissemination.¹ To be a film theorist was not just to participate in a discipline. It was to seek to do good in the world by creating a counterideology and a concomitant counterpractice. Film theorists at this time wrote explicitly against the propagation of dominant values for a presumptive readership of fellow oppressed victims of structures of racism, patriarchy, and capitalism.

This was a shift. When we speak of “classical” film theory, we generally refer to essays that either considered film as an almost magical, humanist new art form that promised transcendence of, and over, a mundane material world or that considered cinema to be an art form rooted in mechanicity, a symptom of industrialization and consumerism. By focusing on the ideology of movies, and of the viewing of movies (sound was rarely a concern at this time), theorists changed the scene by applying systems of thought—particularly Marxism, psychoanalysis, and semiotics—to films as a means of leftist and liberal political progress. This is not to say that the transformation was entirely smooth, as evident in one of the more contentious, formative debates in the field a few years later, between Stephen Heath and Noël Carroll. Carroll wrote a harsh seventy-four-page critique of Heath’s 1981 book, *Questions of Cinema*, largely because Heath’s cinematic questions concerned ideology and not aesthetics (which Carroll regarded as antithetical). Heath responded with a retort to “Le Père Noël” by arguing that ideology was not some ignorable-at-will epiphenomenon but constitutive of subjectivity. At odds in this debate, too, was the matter of truth. Heath drew on the rationales of Althusser and Lacan to mount his critique, accusing Carroll of an overattachment to science, claiming that, for Carroll, “Science is the absolute truth of the world itself, and all social, historical, political questions are ruled out of court.”²

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I will return to this opposition between truth and ideology critique in a moment, but first I want to point out that both writers were implicitly appealing to common sense, too. For Carroll, common sense was (problematically) an innocent, shared ground, whereas for Heath common sense was both a method

and a target, inasmuch as ideological values typically condition what is understood to be common sense in the first place. Their disagreement helps to highlight a certain precarity to theoretical work, one that I want to argue in favor of here. When Mulvey decided to weaponize psychoanalysis to make her case about camera perspective, the sex of characters, and identification, she asserted that audiences identify with the camera's and character's gazes. Was her argument made in terms of a formal or logical proof? Did she survey all of Hollywood history in order to convince her reader? Perhaps not, but that was not her aim. Theorists *make cases*. In many cases a theoretical point makes good sense for good reasons, and, more important, can reach further into cultural politics and highlight the way that films, in turn, shape cultural assumptions about what counts as common sense altogether. This is all to say that theory can be and remain conjectural, even tentative. Eugenie Brinkema describes the "true task" of theory: "*theoria*, contemplation, speculation, to look at something (otherwise; in a new light)."³ Theory is, in this sense, creative. It creates new ways of seeing things. Its power lies in being "really useful," as Christine Gledhill and Linda Williams write in their important collection, *Reinventing Film Theory*—arguably the last anthology of film theory that, like this one, eschews surveys of keywords and concepts in favor of fresh interventions, questions, and arguments.⁴ More broadly, Stuart Hall also endorses a utilitarian view of theory: "The purpose of theorizing is not to enhance one's intellectual or academic reputation but to enable us to grasp, understand, and explain ... the historical world and its processes; and thereby to inform our practice so that we may transform it."⁵

Yet why, if theory is so positive, so promising, have we arrived at a moment when many find the very thought of theory repellent? Brinkema laments this current situation: “theory is being surpassed, elegized, ignored, and derided, and yet so very many of us still crave its appearance, its surprises, and its speculations.”⁶ There are certainly good intellectual reasons for turning away from film theory as it traditionally shaped itself, heavily favoring intellectual inheritances from white cishet cultures within American/French/German/British geopolitical boundaries. One can lay the blame for objectionable canons of films and auteurs at the feet of this history, too. And, in fact, many of the most exciting scholars working on issues of decoloniality, indigeneity, race, and gender diversity today have turned away from film theory, gravitating instead toward the recovery of the historical archive, or to the study of other media now more popular than cinema. Film is no longer, as Hungarian film theorist Béla Balázs declared in 1945, the “potentially greatest instrument of mass cultural influence ever devised in the whole course of human cultural history.”⁷

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Moreover, there was at the turn of the last century a sense that film theory had reached an impasse. David Bordwell and Noël Carroll famously narrated the “posttheory” sensibility into being in 1996, and anxiety about making ambitious theoretical claims emerged, coinciding with anxiety about the move from cinematic images that result from light projected through celluloid to digital image-making technologies. Mary Ann Doane, for example, worried: “What happens to a discipline on the verge of the disappearance of its object, or, to put it more conservatively, in the face of the perception of the death of its object?”⁸ Together, these anxieties motivated a resurgence in cinephilia, a sense that film

scholars should cherish the medium they feared losing—and cinephilia was positioned as “the antithesis of theory.”⁹ At the same time, too, the field began to shift its self-identification. Programs and departments previously called “film studies” became “film and media studies” or simply “media studies.” In large part these changes sought to be inclusive of what was called “new media.” However, there was also confusion in this respect, as studies of new media insisted they were a “new language” (Manovich) that required a “new philosophy” (Hansen).¹⁰ Film theory’s ongoing relevance was thus unclear.

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As a result, we might say that in fact both parts of the equation “film theory” were under attack. Although more attention has been paid to the effects of digital technology on “film,” there was a displacement of “theory” by “philosophy.” Leading film theorists, such as D. N. Rodowick, argued that film theory had effectively lost its momentum and much of its significance and was necessarily replaced by film and philosophy. Symptomatically, at the same time that the Society for Cinema and Media Studies’ film theory scholarly interest group folded, a Film-Philosophy interest group was formed, which continues to thrive. Indeed, many scholars who, in the last century, might have become film theorists now identify as working in the area of “film and philosophy,” or “film-philosophy” as the journal of that title would have it (to connote the sense that films can themselves *do* philosophy). And this is perhaps a starting point for undertaking the difficult task of distinguishing between philosophy and theory, which Brinkema calls “one of the most fraught questions of our current scholarly moment.”¹¹ There was never a journal called *Film-Theory*, after all, and few ever felt the need to make the case that films *do* theory. The turn away from theory in

this context seems to ask, “Who needs theory when we can have philosophy?” Those who would feel no need to answer this question are likely drawn to the cultural prestige attached to “philosophy,” with its ties to ancient legacies of originary insights, and with a practical benefit of convincing deans or readers to pony up funds.

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I cannot help but recall, however, Marx’s famous words, “The philosophers have only interpreted the world, in various ways; the point is to change it.”¹² So beyond respectability politics, I want to somewhat polemically interrogate the need to consider film under the aegis of “philosophy,” as it, perhaps surprisingly, suggests that the tension between Carroll and Heath—between logicoscientific truth and ideology critique—was never quite resolved.¹³ For one thing, practitioners of film and philosophy are more often inclined to invoke rather vague notions of what philosophy is rather than engage deeply with the work of any particular philosopher, suggesting a certain shakiness in the subdiscipline’s self-assurance. But first we should not overestimate the novelty of believing film to be of philosophical interest. Although he was technically a psychologist, Hugo Münsterberg’s well-known 1916 study, *The Photoplay: A Psychological Study*, today reads as a text belonging to the area of film and philosophy. He argues that films may shed light on particular mental activities due to cinema’s ability to formally imitate them so well. In 1918, Louis Aragon writes of film’s “philosophic qualities,” in terms of its ability to reveal reality to us in a new, aestheticized manner—and especially an ordinary kind of reality, one made up of objects familiar to the audience.¹⁴

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Take a more complex example from Alfred Hitchcock's *North by Northwest* (1958) (Hitchcock being precisely the kind of filmmaker that motivated film theory in the first place, as well as a source of fascination for film and philosophy). A scene opens at a train station. Whether or not it's a set, it convincingly appears to be a real train station. Next, we see Roger Thornhill (Cary Grant) and Eve Kendall (Eva Marie Saint) stepping down from the train and onto the platform. She is trying to help him evade the authorities, so when they spy a couple of lawmen, Eve tells Roger to "go on ahead" while she approaches them. Hitchcock then cuts to her talking to the two men, but now the background is a bit off. Hitchcock has filmed the set and then rear-projected the image behind them. At the moment she lies to these men, so, too, is the image no longer to be trusted (in the same way). There is thus an internal relation occurring between kinds of images within the film and a seeming awareness of their natures. Such moments can *feel* philosophical due to their reflexive condition.

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Without denying the force of such affects, I also suspect that the air of philosophy that surrounds film has to do with problems raised by attempting to talk about it. In describing a moving moment, for example, we may want to say "X film shows us a close-up of Y's hand." But how odd? That close-up *is* the film. Does it make good sense to say that the film shows itself to us in this moment? Or, "then there is a close-up of Y's hand." This feels more accurate but still does not quite find a way to talk about the thing itself. Nor does "then Y's hand fills the screen." My point is that without interjecting a hypothetical agency, as when we speak of a director's choices as manifest, or say "the film cuts to," "then the camera pans upward," and so forth, movies are difficult to talk about. It's not that these

descriptions are senseless but that they are, strictly speaking, false. We do not *see* the film cutting or the camera panning. We see one shot after another and objects drifting out of frame in just that way. Our dependence upon these metaphors suggests a duality to the text, as though it exists in relation to itself. This can create a sense that the medium grasps itself, that it is a subject, perhaps capable of self-understanding, and maybe, then, capable of doing something we might call philosophy.

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But whether or not films can properly do philosophy, or whether or not philosophy can be done *through* film, is less relevant to understanding film and philosophy's contrast with film theory than the kind of questions asked in each area. Writing in 2006, Noël Carroll and Jinhee Choi state that "philosophical attention" to the medium "has grown exponentially" in their introduction to *Philosophy of Film and Motion Pictures: An Anthology*. They define "philosophical attention" in this way:

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In contrast to empirical research, philosophy is the discipline that is primarily preoccupied with the "logic" or conceptual frameworks of our practices. So a philosophical perspective on the motion picture involves attending to the conceptual frameworks of our motion picture practices. This includes: (1) the analysis of the concepts and categories that organize our practices (for example, asking what is film or what is a documentary?); (2) the clarification of the relations between those organizing concepts and categories (for example, can what falls under the category of film also fall under the category of art, or is there some reason that precludes the former from being an instance of the latter?); (3) the resolution of the conceptual paradoxes, tensions, and contradictions that the

relevant practices appear to provoke (for example, how is it possible for us to fear fiction films?); (4) the elucidation of the forms of reasoning—the modes of connecting concepts—appropriate to our practices (for example, what techniques of interpretation are suitable or valid with respect to classic Hollywood movies?); and (5) the discovery of the metaphysical presuppositions and entailments of the conceptual frameworks of the relevant practices (for example, what kind of narrators, ontologically speaking, do fiction films presuppose?)¹⁵

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What I find striking about this thorough effort to map out new philosophical terrain is how familiar the questions Carroll and Choi pose would have been to film theorists in previous decades. Questions of generic taxonomy, spectatorship, aesthetics, narrative, interpretation, and so forth *were* theoretical questions. More recently, to take just one other example among many, in 2017 Bernd Herzogenrath writes in the collection *Film as Philosophy* that “during the past ten to fifteen years, the convergence of film studies and philosophy has become ‘the next big thing’ in (not only) the field of media studies,” yet the book includes chapters on writers such as Jean Epstein, Béla Balázs, and André Bazin, thinkers who wanted precisely to be dubbed theorists as opposed to critics.¹⁶ (Bazin states quite plainly of his method: “I apologize for proceeding by way of metaphor, but I am not a philosopher and I cannot convey my meaning any more directly.”¹⁷)